Given that Bharat was (and remains) the land of heathendom in the eyes of the Christian coloniser, it was axiomatic that false religion abounded and immorality prospered. This laid the foundations of the colonial stereotype that the indigenous idol-worshipping Hindu was ‘untrustworthy, immoral, corrupt and cowardly’ and compared poorly to the ‘unyielding Muslim’ who, though he rejected the gospel, was closer to the Christian worldview, being ‘of the book’. These stereotypes continue to find purchase long after the British have left, proving the continued existence of colonial consciousness. In other words, the continuity between the ‘fundamental and structural descriptions’ of Bharat by the British and the manner in which ‘independent’ generations have viewed Bharat’s past and present are evidence of colonial consciousness being alive and kicking. While this continuity of thought is laid at the doors of Bharat’s indigeneity by the postcolonial school, given the latter’s perception of Bharat as an inherently weak and servile civilisation, according to Balagangadhara and De Roover, colonial consciousness must be held responsible for such continuity of thought.

They identify the presence of such continuity in the critical realm of faith that led to ‘Buddhism’ and ‘Jainism’ being reshaped and reimagined as rebellions against ‘Brahminical hegemony’, which re-imagination was evidently inspired by the anti-clericalism of the Protestant Reformation. Further, the project of ‘reforming’ native faith systems and practices, which found enthusiastic native takers during the colonial period and spawned several ‘reformist’ movements, continues to find purchase in contemporary Bharat regardless of political or ideological labels, such as the Left or the Right.

This is not to contend that but for the impact of coloniality/colonial consciousness Bharat’s society was without the need for forward movement. That is an entirely different line of enquiry altogether which cannot be embarked upon until there is a decolonialised understanding of precolonial Bharat’s indigenous culture and society. The point being advanced is that the framework of our discussions, conversations and debates, and its undergirding are predominantly colonial and until that lens is replaced with the indigenous lens, there is no scope for an honest discussion on the need for ‘reform’.

In this regard, Balagangadhara and De Roover are of the view that replacement of colonial consciousness with native/Indic consciousness